including Abdullah and Qanooni was relatively diminished in New Delhi after the Bonn conference. Karzai's victory in the 2004 national elections played a decisive role in tilting India towards Karzai as opposed to his opponents. Soon after the elections, India replaced Katju with Rakesh Sood as ambassador to Kabul with a mandate to deepen engagement with Karzai and invest more in Pashtun leaders (such as Gul Agha Sherzai, the governor of Nangarhar) and communities. India's outreach to political personalities in Pashtun-dominated areas had begun in earnest.

Unlike previous Afghan presidents such as Karmal and Najibullah, who were widely considered Soviet stooges, Karzai demonstrated a fiercely independent streak with his Western benefactors. This was especially visible on issues such as reconciling with the Taliban and talking to Pakistan. Such independence made him even more attractive in New Delhi. For, if his outreach to Pakistan in the initial years of his presidency appealed to the conciliators, his anti-Pakistan activism instilled faith among the partisans in later years. Traditional partisans like Katju and R continued to nurture suspicions about Karzai, but conciliators such as Singh, Menon, Prasad, Rakesh Sood, Mukhopadhaya, and even home minister P. Chidambaram viewed his novelty and political dexterity as a blessing to reconnect with Afghanistan's Pashtun communities. Even those partisans without the political baggage of the 1990s Afghan civil war, such as Narayanan, viewed Karzai as an ally and an asset. Such convergence of ideas within India's power circles about supporting Karzai, made Indian policymakers accept the cost of such support (i.e. irritating, if not alienating, former UF leaders). Not only was Karzai sensitive to Indian interests in Afghanistan, he also wanted to develop strategic parity with Pakistan on his own will, and thus addressed India's political desire of striking a strategic balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan.

Indian calculations about Karzai was correct on each count. He welcomed India in a big way despite the West and Pakistan's reservations. Well aware of the multiple levers at work in the India-Pakistan relationship, Karzai had learnt to willfully and skillfully exploit them. His offer to Jaswant Singh, in early 2002, to mediate between India and Pakistan (scoffed at by Abdullah as being naïve), thus, was as much a gesture of goodwill as much it was a failed Machiavellian ploy to shape India-Pakistan rivalry to Afghanistan's advantage. His adept diplomacy in